v. Board of Education, the uneven adherence to the decision led to further domestic unrest and divisive, violent tactics by local authorities. In the aftermath of the case that struck down "Separate but Equal" governance as unconstitutional, the broad legal and social system of segregation continued widely across the South and the North. Through a hybrid of law, custom, and architectural design, America's own segregated sectors—including geographic places under racial rule as well as contexts of institutional discrimination in education, health, housing, and labor—reinforced the social construction of consequential racial hierarchies. In May 1961 the first Freedom Rides organized by the Congress of Racial Equality tested the desegregation of interstate bus travel. Sit-ins at lunch counters and other public venues continued to contest the undignified rituals of segregated business-as-usual. These protests also pointed to the existing barriers—both symbolic and physical—that had plagued the United States and called into question its identity as an "indivisible" nation.[11]

American cultural productions from the late summer through the end of 1961, immediately before and after the Berlin Wall's initial construction, drew focus to the city's internal border through reportage and fictional crossings, at times with attention to the interrelated dynamics of geopolitical and racial division. In a column published August 12, 1961, one day before East Berlin sealed its borders, the celebrated poet and author Langston Hughes wrote an editorial in the *Chicago Defender* titled "Beer, Berlin and Simple." The column was a pointed response to an earlier, pre-Wall address by President John F. Kennedy televised to the nation on July 22, 1961, in which he addressed the Berlin Crisis and increasingly tense communications with the Soviet Union following a July summit with Premier Nikita Khrushchev in Vienna. Hughes wrote in one of his often-used editorial forms, presenting an imagined conversation with "Jesse B. Semple," commonly known as "Simple," a fictional fellow Harlem resident. Simple's ideas reflect common but critical negotiations of domestic and global politics as they existed at that moment.

As Hughes writes from Simple's perspective, he states, "In the next war I'll have to fight for Berlin. I had rather fight for Birmingham." Simple goes on to contextualize the latest crisis in terms of his fears of recent German history ("It were but a short time ago that Berlin was fighting me") as well as America divided internally by Jim Crow laws and customs ("I'll bet Mississippi has WHITE and COLORED air raid shelters").[12]